

HIGH SCHOOLS

Olmsted Falls, Benedictine post tough victories

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

TOLEDO — Thanks to a gutsy effort by Olmsted Falls and a strong second half by Benedictine, the Greater Cleveland area continued to make its mark in boys regional basketball play.

BOYS BASKETBALL

Olmsted Falls, on the strength of a soft, fall-away jumper by All-Ohio senior center Tim Schaefer with four seconds left, defeated Bellevue, 51-50, in overtime last night in the second game of a Division II regional semifinal doubleheader in the University of Toledo's Savage Hall.

The Bulldogs, who overcame a 14-point deficit early in the third quarter, set up an all-Cleveland area regional final.

Olmsted Falls (23-1), which extended its winning streak to 17 games, will face Benedictine (20-5) in tomorrow's 3 p.m. championship game in Savage Hall. St. Edward (23-1) and Valley Forge (19-5) will take the Savage Hall court at 7:30 tomorrow night with a Division I regional championship on the line.

Benedictine, picking up its defensive pressure and going strong to both backboards, held off Elida, 74-68, in last night's first game.

"It's been that way all year," said Benedictine coach Frank Novak. "We just never seem to come

out in the first quarter and go right after it..."

Trailing, 35-34, midway through the third quarter, Benedictine's whole attitude seemed to change.

Becoming more aggressive at both ends of the court, the Bengals took a 39-35 lead on a driving left-hander by senior guard Rashon Brown and a 3-pointer by sophomore guard Chris Leanza.

Outrebounded, 23-15, in the first half, Benedictine, with 6-7 junior Albert Wilson showing the way, started to control the offensive backboard.

A putback by Leanza and a jumper by 6-6 sophomore Jermaine Crosby pushed the Bengals' lead to 45-38 and, on the strength of a 3-pointer by sopho-

more guard Michael Woods, Benedictine held a 50-42 lead entering the final eight minutes.

Benedictine moved to a 57-44 lead on a strong penetration move by Brown with 5:40 left.

Following a timeout, Elida, which was making its second regional appearance, put together a 10-2 run and cut the deficit to 59-54 on two free throws by senior Steve Creps with 2:54 left.

After a 3-pointer by Woods and two free throws by Wilson gave the Bengals a 67-59 lead with 1:11 to play, Elida responded with a three-point play by Creps and trailed, 67-64, after senior forward Matt Metzger hit two free throws with 55.9 seconds left.

Benedictine kept its composure, however, and advanced to

the title game behind the free-throw shooting of Leanza, Wilson and Brown.

In the second game, Bellevue rode five 3-pointers to an 18-9 lead after the first quarter.

Olmsted Falls, champion of the Southwestern Conference, closed to 25-20 on two free throws by senior forward Jim Kalemba with 2:12 remaining in the first half.

But Bellevue answered with a layup by senior forward Chad Cramer and a 3-pointer by junior forward David Falknor and led, 30-20, at halftime.

After falling behind, 34-20, early in the third quarter, Olmsted Falls turned to Schaefer and the two-time player of the year in the SWC brought the Bulldogs to within a basket, 36-34, with less

than a minute left in the quarter. Olmsted Falls led, 44-42, after Schaefer made a strong move along the baseline with 1:43 left in regulation.

Bellevue tied it at 44 on a layup by Falknor with 1:18 left and, after Olmsted Falls missed a shot from the right baseline, the teams faced a four-minute overtime.

In overtime, Bellevue (22-3) took a 48-44 lead with 2:31 to play. Undaunted, Olmsted Falls settled into its half-court offense and took a 49-48 lead on a 3-pointer by All-District senior guard John Storey with 1:03 left.

Trailing, 50-49, the Bulldogs called a timeout with 14.6 seconds left and called on Schaefer, who took a pass from Storey and hit the game winner.

Shots don't fall

Lake Catholic eliminated by subpar shooting

By MIKE PETICCA
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

The one thing that can betray a basketball team, no matter how hard it plays, is shooting.

BOYS BASKETBALL

Last night, Lake Catholic's boys lost a Division II regional semifinal game to Youngstown Cardinal Mooney, 66-64, on a follow shot by Mooney's Josh Allegretto with 1.7 seconds remaining.

That was one play, though. What made the difference was Lake Catholic's 39 percent field-goal shooting. The Cougars won their first three tournament games while making 55 percent of their shots.

"We didn't do that tonight," Lake Catholic coach Pat Lyons said of the team's off-night of shooting. "And our goal was to eliminate their second shots, and we just didn't do it."

Mooney (17-8) has won 13 of its last 15 games. The Cardinals will play Buchtel (19-5) for the regional championship and a trip to the state tournament tomorrow at 3.

Buchtel defeated Canton South (17-7), 48-45, in last night's first game in University of Akron's JAR Arena. Doylan Robinson scored 14 points and grabbed 10 rebounds for Buchtel, and Tim Ross had 22 points and 14 rebounds for South.

Mooney advanced to regional title games in 1994 and 1995. The Cardinals lost to eventual state champions Youngstown Ursuline and Orrville, respectively.

Lake Catholic (15-9) had a six-game winning streak snapped while playing in its first regional game since a 1980 semifinal defeat to St. Ignatius.

Jason Battung led Lake Catholic with 19 points, including five 3-point shots, the last one on a pass from Ryan Weiler that tied the game at 64 with 20 seconds left.

The Cougars forced Mooney to take a contested baseline jumper with five seconds to go. Their defensive effort left a clear path to the basket for Allegretto, who jumped, caught the ball and banked in the game-winning shot.

Lake Catholic and Mooney both called timeouts. The Cardinals stole the Cougars' long inbound pass as the clock ran out.

Allegretto scored 20 points and



Lake Catholic's Mike Hill goes up for a shot against Robert Curd of Youngstown Cardinal Mooney. Hill had 12 points and 12 rebounds for the Cougars.

had nine rebounds. Robert Curd and Mike Venrose each scored 13 points for Mooney, and Matt Kempe came off the bench to get eight points and 11 rebounds.

The Cardinals shot 54 percent, and Allegretto's putback was symptomatic of another Cougar problem throughout the game. Mooney outrebounded Lake Catholic, 36-27.

Mike Hill had 12 points and 12 rebounds for the Cougars. Matt Brickman, Aaron Crock and Keith Lillash scored 10, nine and eight points, respectively.

Battung hit a 26-foot, 3-point shot to cut a Mooney lead to 48-47

with 7:15 remaining. The Cougars didn't score again until Crock hit a 3-pointer with 3:02 left, leaving Mooney ahead, 58-50.

During the Cougars' scoring drought, they missed nine straight shots and committed three turnovers.

Mooney used the opportunity for a 10-0 run. Venrose and Curd each made a jump shot and a layup during the spurt.

Mooney helped the Cougars get back in the game by missing 8 of 12 free throws in the last 3:12.

Lillash hit a 3-point shot, a layup and converted a fast-break layup after making a steal. Ryan

Weiler made a layup and Crock hit a jumper before Battung's game-tying 3-pointer.

Mooney made 17 of 26 field-goal attempts to lead, 39-32, at halftime. Allegretto scored 14 points and had five rebounds, while Battung made all four of his shots, including two 3-pointers, for 10 points.

The Cardinals had 10 fast-break points in the first two quarters, to six for the Cougars. Mooney's final four baskets of the half came in transition, with Curd getting a follow shot, Nick Hellman converting two layups and Andy Bushey hitting a short jumper.

Foul shots give Buchtel winning edge

By EL ROGERS
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Somebody once wrote the tongue is like a two-edged sword.

Well, somebody sliced and diced the dickens out of the basketball referees last night at the University of Akron.

BOYS BASKETBALL

"I didn't see what their coach said when he got those technicals," said Buchtel boys basketball player Doylan Robinson. "I really didn't see what happened."

Something happened. Somebody on Canton South's coaching staff peppered some spicy words to one of the referees. And, of course, referees can only take so much. And, of course, after Canton South was hit with two technicals, Buchtel used that critical moment to propel itself to a 48-45 victory in the Division II regional semifinals.

And, of course, that means Buchtel will meet Youngstown Mooney in tomorrow's 3 p.m. regional finals. And, of course, the

winner of that contest will trek to Columbus for the state final four.

And, of course, you want to hear more about those two technicals, right?

"My guys worked too hard for this," said Canton South coach Henry Cobb, who blamed himself for much of the loss after the game.

Here's how the technicals unfolded: There was 1:27 left in the game. Canton South (17-7) led Buchtel (19-6), 44-43. Canton South's 6-7 sophomore post player, Roy Geer (15 points), had just picked up his fifth foul.

"He's a good player, but the guy had been hooking us the whole game," said Buchtel coach Harvey Sims, whose team got 14 points from Robinson and 11 from Andre Sims.

Geer exited the game. Canton South's bench was not pleased with the foul called on Geer. A few choice words poured forth. First technical. A few more choice words cascaded onto the refs' ears. Second technical. Upon picking up his second technical, Cobb had to leave the court. He

said very little after the game.

"I didn't see what happened," Harvey Sims said.

After everything was sorted out, here's what Buchtel got to do: shoot six free throws and take the ball out. That meant the Griffins could have racked up eight straight points, possibly nine if they made a 3-pointer.

"We had our best free-throw shooters at the line," said Harvey Sims, whose team made 11 of 19 free throws. "I would put the same guys on the line right now if I had to."

Robinson missed the front end of a one-and-one, which meant he didn't get a second shot. Andre Sims made two of the four technical foul shots. Buchtel took the ball out and was fouled. But the Griffins failed to make another front end of a one-and-one attempt.

In other words, Buchtel came away with two points. But those points were precious. Buchtel took a 45-44 lead with the free throws and never trailed again.

"I still felt our defense would do it for us," Harvey Sims said.

With 21 seconds left and Buchtel leading, 46-45, Canton South failed to take advantage of a golden opportunity when it missed a wide-open layup.

"Their guy was wide open when he missed that," said Buchtel's Destin Scott. "When you're that wide open, you're supposed to put that in."

Robinson drained two free throws with 20 seconds left to give his team a 48-45 edge. Canton South never recovered.

"They were really tough," said Buchtel's Kevin Harvey. "They surprised me. I think when that guy missed that layup for them, he was probably a little nervous."

Canton South led, 9-8, after one quarter. Buchtel led, 22-19, at halftime. The Griffins built that lead to 33-25 with four minutes left in the third quarter on a 3-pointer by Sims.

But Canton South, which got 22 points from Tim Ross, pecked away. Trailing, 37-31, entering the fourth, Canton South eventually tied the game, 39-39, with 5:13 left. From there, the teams battled down the stretch.

Firestone's surge shocks Mentor

By TIM WARSINSKEY
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

How quickly joy can become grief for one team while doom finds an alibi for another.

Mentor, seemingly on the verge of its first regional tournament victory, was swallowed

by Firestone's stunning comeback in the Falcons' 71-66 semifinal triumph last night in the Canton Civic Center.

Firestone trailed by 11 points with 2:58 remaining and won the game with an unexpected defensive storm, including six steals in the last two minutes, while also sinking clutch shot after clutch shot.

"They had our backs against the wall," said Falcons guard Derek Williams, whose running 3-pointer gave Firestone a one-point lead with 25 seconds remaining. "We never gave up. We just kept playing hard."

That the Falcons are playing for the regional title is, for some, as surprising as their comeback last night. But here they are. The Falcons advance to tomorrow's Division I regional final against Cleveland Heights (21-4) at 7:30 p.m. in the Civic Center.

Firestone has had a habit of playing up — or down — to the level of its opponent. Last night, the Falcons were just plain up and down. They got back up at the last possible moment.

"We've been 20-point underdogs in every game since we started this tournament, and the kids just don't care what other people think about them," coach Steve Culp said. "All we hear is, 'Firestone doesn't have a chance.' But we're still here."

"The kids never panicked. They played together so well. They kept the defensive intensity up and helped each other out."

For Mentor (16-8), the loss was devastating. Players and coaches were red-eyed; they shared few words and plenty of mournful hugs after the game.

"What makes it doubly tough is

that we were on an eight-game winning streak, and we beat Glenville in the district final," coach Bob Krizancic said. "They were on such a high confidence level, and that makes it so much worse."

Krizancic was standing outside the locker room, dreading the scene that awaited him.

"I have to go in there and see Jason Schefft and Jason Woleben, and I'll just break down," he said. "They're like family to me, for three years I've had them. It's real emotional."

Mentor led, 62-51, after two free throws by junior guard Brian Kroccheck, who played an outstanding game with 24 points.

Firestone's Jullian Levy (22 points) fueled the comeback with nine consecutive and unanswered points as he cut Mentor's lead to 62-60.

A turning point came when point guard Schefft fouled out with 2:16 remaining. The Cardinals were lost without Schefft, who scored seven points in 19 minutes. The Falcons switched to a zone-trap defense and Mentor was unable to handle the pressure. It had centers and power forwards handling the ball at midcourt, which was easy pickings for the quicker Falcons.

Mentor's Woleben (15 points) sank two free throws for a 64-60 lead and Williams answered with a clutch shot on a spin move under the basket. After a free throw by Mentor's Gary Lane (15 points), Jullian Levy scored with one minute left to pull the Falcons within a point, 65-64.

Justin Levy stole a pass on Mentor's next possession, and Williams hit his big 3-pointer on the right wing. Kroccheck had a chance to tie it, but he split a pair of free throws. Mentor caught a break when Firestone failed to inbound the ball. The Cardinals' next play broke down when Lane drove toward the basket and dished off to Bob Sivik; but Firestone tipped it away with 10 seconds remaining. Two free throws apiece by Justin Levy and Williams (13 points) clinched the victory.

BY THE NUMBERS

BOYS BASKETBALL

Division I Regional

Canton Civic Center

March 12: Cleveland Hts. 82, Canton McKinley 69

Yesterday: Firestone 71, Mentor 66

Tomorrow: Cleveland Hts. (21-3) vs. Firestone (16-8), 7:30

Columbus Fairgrounds Coliseum

March 12: Dayton Dunbar 73, Galloway Westland 64

Yesterday: Zanesville 57, Columbus Independence 46

Tomorrow: Dayton Dunbar (20-4) vs. Zanesville (23-1), 7:30

University of Dayton

Yesterday: Cincinnati Aiken 76, Cincinnati Princeton 74, 201; Springfield North 78, Trowood-Madison 60

Tomorrow: Cincinnati Aiken (21-3) vs. Springfield North (19-6), 7:30

University of Akron

Yesterday: Buchtel 48, Canton South 45; Youngstown Mooney 66, Lake Catholic 64

Tomorrow: Buchtel (19-6) vs. Youngstown Mooney (17-8), 3

University of Toledo

Yesterday: Benedictine 74, Elida 68; Olmsted Falls 51, Bellevue 50, OT

Tomorrow: Benedictine (20-5) vs. Olmsted Falls (23-1), 3

Ohio University

Yesterday: Hillsboro 69, Circleville 56; Columbus Milfin 62, Dover 48

Tomorrow: Hillsboro (18-5) vs. Columbus Milfin (20-3), 3

Wright State University

Yesterday: Cincinnati Roger Bacon 88, Big Walnut 59; Hamilton Badin 62, Kettering Alter 50

Tomorrow: Roger Bacon (21-4) vs. Hamilton, Badin (19-5), 1

Division III

Canton Fieldhouse

March 12: Villa Angela-St. Joseph 66, Louisville Aquinas 46; Youngstown Liberty 54, Youngstown Ursuline 51

Tomorrow: Villa Angela-St. Joseph (17-6) vs. Youngstown Liberty (21-4), 7:30

Bowling Green

March 12: Patrick Henry 69, Evergreen 52; Ohio 59, Clearview 54

Tomorrow: Patrick Henry (20-4) vs. Ontario (23-1), 7:30

Shenandoah

March 12: Belpre 62, Chesapeake 59; Shenandoah 65, Ballou 59

Tomorrow: Belpre (13-12) vs. Shenandoah (22-2), 7:30

University of Dayton

March 12: Dayton Christian 67, Marion Elgin 66; Cincinnati Wyoming 59, Johnstown Northridge 56

Tomorrow: Dayton Christian (22-3) vs. Cincinnati Wyoming (12-13), 3:30

Division IV

Canton Fieldhouse

March 11: Cantonfieldhouse 54, McDonald 45; Cuyahoga Hts. 64, Madison 50

Today: Zanesville Rosecrans (24-1) vs. Cuyahoga Hts. (18-5), 7:30

University of Toledo

March 11: Unionville 61, McComb 51; Leipsic 46, Holgate 31

Today: Unionville (24-0) vs. Leipsic (23-1), 7:30

Columbus Fairgrounds Coliseum

March 11: Norwalk St. Paul 70, Worthington Christian 67; St. Henry 61, Franklin Furnace Green 52

Today: Norwalk St. Paul (23-2) vs. St. Henry (20-4), 7:30

University of Dayton

March 11: Anna 73, Newton 55; Springfield Catholic 63, Franklin-Monroe 53

Today: Anna (21-4) vs. Springfield Catholic (11-13), 7:30

REGIONAL PAIRINGS

Division I

University of Toledo

March 12: St. Edward 78, Fremont Ross 48; Valley